

TAKING THE WORLD STAGE

It's time to embrace and better represent our diverse film industry, with its wide range of languages and storytelling styles, each with its unique flavour



By **Guneet Monga Kapoor**

From silent films to multilingual productions, Indian cinema has evolved dramatically over the past century. The term 'Bollywood', derived from combining Bombay (now Mumbai) and Hollywood, might be more familiar but suggests a narrow focus and global visibility on one segment of Indian filmmaking. Indian cinema is truly an amalgamation of a broad spectrum that tells stories across regional languages, cultures, and narratives. It's time to embrace 'Indian Cinema', and better represent our extensive and diverse film industry. Indian cinema includes a wide range of languages and storytelling styles, each with its unique flavour. Our cinema has always been a vibrant mix of music, dance, and storytelling. This tradition is deeply embedded in our cultural fabric. Pathbreaking filmmakers like K. Asif, Sanjay Leela Bhansali, and Anurag Kashyap have used music as a crucial element in their storytelling, shaping the narrative and enhancing the emotional impact of their films. This blend of music and storytelling is a hallmark of Indian cinema, reflecting our love for songs and dance while also evolving with contemporary trends and innovative storytelling.

Indian cinema gained international recognition thanks to the efforts of veteran filmmakers such as Bimal Roy, Satyajit Ray, Mrinal Sen, Adoor Gopalakrishnan, Shyam Benegal, Ketan Mehta, Mira Nair, Kalpana Lajmi, and Sudhir Mishra. Funded largely by the National Film Development Corporation of India (NFDC), these filmmakers showcased Indian stories on the global stage and received acclaim at international film festivals. However, the '90s and 2000s saw a shift towards Bollywood's love stories, exotic locales, and larger-than-life productions, which often overshadowed the middle class as they majorly delved into the complexities and

THE GIANT STEPS

- The rise of OTT platforms has both helped with distribution of independent films and made it easier to access films from different regions
- The recognition received by Indian films on global platforms is a testament to Indian cinema's richness and diversity
- Overcoming language barriers and nurturing global partnerships with film festivals and distribution networks are crucial to further push this